

Anime Starter Watchlist 2026

23 real titles from the GameCastle catalog, arranged as a practical roadmap with episode counts, genres and concise spoiler-free overviews.

23 titles	15 pages	10+ genres
Spoiler-light	Beginner roadmap	Free tracker included

Catalog snapshot: August 14, 2026. Ratings are GameCastle editorial scores, not live third-party rankings.

How to use this watchlist

Start with one short or completed series, then move into a longer franchise only after you know which genres and pacing styles you enjoy. The list is not a universal ranking; it is a structured sampler drawn from the titles GameCastle currently covers in depth.

1. Pick by commitment

Choose a shorter completed series when you want a clear ending. Select an ongoing title only when you are comfortable waiting for new seasons or checking current episode information before starting.

2. Track progress honestly

Use the included CSV in Excel, Google Sheets or Notion. Record episodes watched, your personal rating and the date you paused. Personal ratings are more useful than copying a public score.

3. Verify changing details

Episode totals for ongoing series can change. Treat the values in this snapshot as a starting point and verify current availability through a licensed streaming service in your country.

Reading key

Field	Meaning
GameCastle rating	Editorial score stored in the current GameCastle catalog.
Episodes	Catalog total at the snapshot date; '?' means the total is still open or not fixed.
Genres	Discovery labels used for internal browsing and related recommendations.
Status	Completed, Ongoing or Upcoming at the catalog snapshot.

A beginner-friendly roadmap

There is no single correct route. This sequence moves from accessible hooks into denser world-building and larger franchise commitments.

Stage 1 - Fast hooks

Death Note, Demon Slayer, Jujutsu Kaisen and Spy x Family offer clear premises and early payoffs.

Stage 2 - Character depth

Attack on Titan, Vinland Saga, Frieren and The Apothecary Diaries reward slower observation.

Stage 3 - Systems and strategy

Hunter x Hunter, Fullmetal Alchemist: Brotherhood, Steins;Gate and Code Geass add layered rules and consequences.

Stage 4 - Long adventures

Naruto, Bleach, Black Clover and One Piece demand more time but build larger worlds and casts.

Stage 5 - Follow your taste

Use genre labels in each card to branch into romance, sports, fantasy, horror, sci-fi or psychological stories.

Before you press play

Check GameCastle's watch-order pages for sequel order and use licensed services for regional availability. This PDF contains no streaming links and does not replace a current availability check.

Watchlist picks 1-2

Catalog group 1 of 12

Naruto

2002 | Completed | Episodes: 220 | GameCastle rating: 8.4/10

Genres: Action / Adventure / Fantasy / Shonen

The orphan who dreamed of being Hokage.

In the hidden leaf village of Konoha, a loud orange-clad orphan named Naruto Uzumaki carries a nine-tailed beast sealed inside him and a promise to himself that he will one day become Hokage. Naruto is a story about identity, loneliness, and the friendships that reshape a broken child into a leader.

One Piece

1999 | Ongoing | Episodes: ? | GameCastle rating: 9.1/10

Genres: Action / Adventure / Fantasy / Shonen / Comedy

A rubber pirate and an ocean the size of a dream.

Twenty-two years after the execution of the Pirate King, a straw-hatted teenager named Monkey D. Luffy sets sail with a crew of misfits to find the treasure called One Piece. It is a story about freedom disguised as an adventure, drawn with such conviction that most weeks it is the most read manga in the world.

Watchlist picks 3-4

Catalog group 2 of 12

Attack on Titan

2013 | Completed | Episodes: 94 | GameCastle rating: 9.0/10

Genres: Action / Drama / Fantasy / Psychological / Horror

The walls were never meant to keep monsters out.

For a hundred years, three concentric walls kept the last of humanity safe from man-eating giants called Titans. On the day the walls broke, a boy named Eren Yeager watched his mother die and swore he would burn every last Titan from the earth. Attack on Titan is a story about how that vow slowly rewrites its own meaning until the boy and the monster are impossible to tell apart.

Demon Slayer

2019 | Ongoing | Episodes: 55 | GameCastle rating: 8.7/10

Genres: Action / Supernatural / Historical / Shonen

A sword, a sister, and a sunlit vow.

In Taisho-era Japan, a coal seller named Tanjiro Kamado comes home to find his family slaughtered and his sister Nezuko turned into a demon. He becomes a demon slayer to protect what's left of her, and by extension, to save every family that isn't strong enough to save itself.

Watchlist picks 5-6

Catalog group 3 of 12

Jujutsu Kaisen

2020 | Ongoing | Episodes: 47 | GameCastle rating: 8.6/10

Genres: Action / Supernatural / School / Shonen

Curses are what humans deserve.

A high schooler named Yuji Itadori swallows a cursed finger to save his classmates and becomes the vessel for a millennia-old curse called Sukuna. Jujutsu Kaisen is a modern shonen that mixes a school-battle premise with the pacing of a horror film and the choreography of a martial-arts epic.

Death Note

2006 | Completed | Episodes: 37 | GameCastle rating: 8.6/10

Genres: Mystery / Psychological / Supernatural / Drama

A god of the new world begins with a notebook.

Light Yagami is bored. He is also the top-ranked high school student in Japan, the son of a Tokyo police chief, and cynical enough to think he can fix the world if given a big enough weapon. Then a shinigami drops a notebook with the power to kill anyone whose name is written in it - and the world's greatest detective, known only as L, comes looking for him.

Watchlist picks 7-8

Catalog group 4 of 12

Fullmetal Alchemist: Brotherhood

2009 | Completed | Episodes: 64 | GameCastle rating: 9.2/10

Genres: Action / Adventure / Drama / Fantasy / Shonen

In order to obtain, something of equal value must be lost.

Two brothers try to bring their mother back from the dead and pay for it with a leg, an arm, and a body. Fullmetal Alchemist: Brotherhood follows their search for the Philosopher's Stone through a country whose military is not what it seems and whose alchemy is drawn from something much older than science.

Hunter x Hunter

2011 | Ongoing | Episodes: 148 | GameCastle rating: 9.1/10

Genres: Action / Adventure / Fantasy / Shonen

A boy in green, a killer in white, and a world too big to conquer.

Gon Freecss wants to find his father. Along the way he becomes a Hunter, meets a boy his own age raised as an assassin, and steps into a story that keeps outgrowing its own shape until it is one of the most ambitious shonen ever drawn.

Watchlist picks 9-10

Catalog group 5 of 12

Chainsaw Man

2022 | Ongoing | Episodes: 12 | GameCastle rating: 8.5/10

Genres: Action / Horror / Supernatural / Shonen

A boy, a devil dog, and a normal life he can't afford.

Denji lives in a shack, eats bread with jam if he's lucky, and hunts devils to pay off his dead father's yakuza debt. He is fused with his pet devil Pochita and becomes Chainsaw Man - a public safety asset with a very small wishlist and a very big weapon.

Solo Leveling

2024 | Ongoing | Episodes: 25 | GameCastle rating: 8.3/10

Genres: Action / Fantasy / Supernatural

The weakest hunter becomes the only one who levels up.

In a world where hunters clear monster gates for a living, Sung Jinwoo is a rank-E chore. After a near-death experience in a double dungeon, a mysterious System gives him a single, unfair gift: he alone can level up.

Watchlist picks 11-12

Catalog group 6 of 12

Frieren: Beyond Journey's End

2023 | Ongoing | Episodes: 28 | GameCastle rating: 9.0/10

Genres: Fantasy / Adventure / Drama / Slice Of Life

The quest is over. The mourning begins.

An elven mage named Frieren outlives her hero party by half a century and slowly realizes that the ten years she spent with them were the shape of her whole life. Frieren is a fantasy about time, memory, and the small acts of understanding we owe the people we outlast.

Spy x Family

2022 | Ongoing | Episodes: 37 | GameCastle rating: 8.5/10

Genres: Action / Comedy / Slice Of Life / Family

A spy, an assassin, a telepath. And they think they're a family.

A master spy adopts a psychic child and marries a professional killer, and none of the three know the truth about the other two. Spy x Family is a warm, precisely written comedy that occasionally turns into a genuine action thriller.

Watchlist picks 13-14

Catalog group 7 of 12

Dragon Ball Z

1989 | Completed | Episodes: 291 | GameCastle rating: 8.2/10

Genres: Action / Adventure / Shonen / Supernatural

The tournament arc that defined the genre.

The direct continuation of Akira Toriyama's Dragon Ball follows Son Goku into adulthood as invaders from his home planet, androids from a broken future, and a pink child-god of destruction turn Earth into the setting for successively larger tournaments of power. Dragon Ball Z did not invent the escalating power scale, but it standardized every convention modern shonen still runs on.

Bleach

2004 | Ongoing | Episodes: ? | GameCastle rating: 8.3/10

Genres: Action / Supernatural / Shonen

A substitute soul reaper and the war he keeps inheriting.

Ichigo Kurosaki inherits the powers of a Soul Reaper by accident and quickly finds himself standing between the living world, the Soul Society, and the Hollows that hunt souls in between. Tite Kubo's series is built around swords, ceremony, and the slow reveal that every faction has been at war with itself for centuries.

Watchlist picks 15-16

Catalog group 8 of 12

My Hero Academia

2016 | Ongoing | Episodes: ? | GameCastle rating: 8.0/10

Genres: Action / Shonen / School / Supernatural

A quirkless boy inherits the greatest hero's power.

In a world where 80% of humanity is born with a superpower called a Quirk, Izuku Midoriya is not. Kohei Horikoshi's series follows Midoriya from the moment the world's greatest hero picks him as a successor, through his years at U.A. High, and into a full-scale war with a villain organization built out of the society hero culture failed.

Jojo's Bizarre Adventure

2012 | Ongoing | Episodes: ? | GameCastle rating: 8.5/10

Genres: Action / Adventure / Supernatural / Shonen

Every generation inherits the fight, and the pose.

Hirohiko Araki's multigenerational saga follows the Joestar family across a century of feuds with an immortal enemy and the strange powers - first Hamon, later Stands - the bloodline develops to fight him. Each part changes protagonist, setting, and genre, but keeps the same operatic sense of style.

Watchlist picks 17-18

Catalog group 9 of 12

One-Punch Man

2015 | Ongoing | Episodes: ? | GameCastle rating: 8.5/10

Genres: Action / Comedy / Supernatural

A hero for fun who wins in one hit.

Saitama is a hero so overpowered that no fight lasts more than a punch. ONE and Yusuke Murata's series is a satire of the power-fantasy shonen genre - its real drama is what happens to a man who solved his own premise on page one.

Mob Psycho 100

2016 | Completed | Episodes: 37 | GameCastle rating: 8.6/10

Genres: Action / Comedy / Supernatural / School

Being kind matters more than being powerful.

Shigeo 'Mob' Kageyama is one of the strongest psychics alive and spends most of his middle-school years trying to become a normal teenager. ONE's second major series is the counter-thesis to One-Punch Man - a story about a boy who can level a city and chooses, every day, not to.

Watchlist picks 19-20

Catalog group 10 of 12

Haikyuu!!

2014 | Completed | Episodes: 85 | GameCastle rating: 8.7/10

Genres: Sports / Drama / School / Shonen

A small player, a big net, and a team learning to fly.

Shoyo Hinata, short even by his generation's standards, joins Karasuno High's volleyball club with one goal: to jump higher than anyone else on the court. Haruichi Furudate's series is one of the most technically respected sports anime ever produced, and Production I.G's adaptation treats every rally like a fight scene.

Blue Lock

2022 | Ongoing | Episodes: ? | GameCastle rating: 8.0/10

Genres: Sports / Drama / Shonen

300 strikers, one project, one selfish egoist to save Japan.

Muneyuki Kaneshiro and Yusuke Nomura's series traps 300 of Japan's most promising strikers in a single facility and asks them to eliminate each other into a single, perfectly selfish World Cup goalscorer. The premise is antithetical to traditional sports-anime team ethics, and that friction is the point.

Watchlist picks 21-22

Catalog group 11 of 12

Black Clover

2017 | Completed | Episodes: 170 | GameCastle rating: 8.1/10

Genres: Action / Fantasy / Magic / Shonen

The one boy in a world of mages who was born without magic.

Y?ki Tabata's series follows Asta, an orphan born with no mana in a kingdom where magic is identity, and Yuno, his rival and best friend, as they both work toward the title of Wizard King. The TV anime ran 170 episodes to the Spade Kingdom raid; the film Sword of the Wizard King continues the story.

Dr. Stone

2019 | Ongoing | Episodes: ? | GameCastle rating: 8.3/10

Genres: Adventure / Sci Fi / Shonen

Rebuilding civilization from zero, one experiment at a time.

Riichiro Inagaki and Boichi's series opens with every human on Earth turned to stone. Thousands of years later, high-school genius Senku Ishigami wakes up and starts rebuilding civilization from first principles. The show is a shonen wrapper around a science-history procedural.

Watchlist picks 23-23

Catalog group 12 of 12

Yu Yu Hakusho

1992 | Completed | Episodes: 112 | GameCastle rating: 8.5/10

Genres: Action / Supernatural / Shonen

A delinquent detective for the spirit world.

Yoshihiro Togashi's series follows Yusuke Urameshi, a teenage delinquent who dies saving a child in the first episode and comes back as Spirit World's official detective. Yu Yu Hakusho ran between Togashi's two masterworks - Slam Dunk-era shonen structure with the tournament rigor Hunter × Hunter would later inherit.